

enforcement of the Nizam-e-Adl Regulations helped us to do that."

Military sources also claim that there is no ambivalence this time about the need to eliminate the militants. "We are not just going for flushing them out, we are going for the kill," says one senior army official. If the ISPR figures are to be believed, some 800 militants of the 4,000 estimated fighters have already been killed. Indications from military sources are also that plans for a massive bombing campaign are afoot, with one air force source claiming it would be the biggest campaign in the air force's history. But there are a number of problems such a military campaign is bound to encounter. The



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foremost among them, obviously, is the issue of "collateral damage". With so many civilians in the line of fire—military sources claim some two lakh are still trapped in the area and that the militants are holding many of them as human shields and have heavily mined areas within Swat to prevent them from leaving—there are bound to be heavy casualties. The alternative to a bombing campaign—a house-to-house fight in densely populated areas such as Swat's capital Mingora—is also likely to result in heavy losses both on the civilian and military sides.

To a large extent, public opinion in Pakistan and the Malakand region has turned against the Taliban, particularly because of the barbarity of their practices such as the filmed beheadings of their enemies, restrictions imposed on and even flogging of women, and their refusal to lay down their arms despite accepting the "peace accord". The refugees streaming out of Malakand are to a large extent supportive of the military operation as long as it finishes the problem once

and for all. But how long that opinion remains in the face of heavy civilian casualties is a million-dollar question. Pakistanis are hoping for a quick and decisive operation. But all indications point to a long-drawn-out operation, even though the military refuses to say this publicly. "This is not going to end in days or weeks," says a military source. Meanwhile, the UNHCR is drawing up plans to house and provide care to the IDPs for up to two years.

Analysts also question whether the military has the capacity to deliver even if its commitment is unquestioned. Judging by its past record in FATA and even in Swat, this is not altogether clear. For example, the only answer army officials have for the inability to target people like Baitullah Mehsud, Fazlullah and others in the past or even to jam their illegal FM radio transmissions is "inefficiency and incompetence". Abbas accepts the weaknesses of the past, but says, "One thing you cannot

doubt is our commitment. No force in the world would have a soft corner for people who have killed its own officers and jawans in such a brutal fashion". Nevertheless, some analysts doubt that the military operation will eliminate all the militants. "There are just too many factors at play here," says one political insider with access to the corridors of power. "Too many competing interests internally, too many international linkages and even the involvement of outside agencies which want to keep this region destabilised."

But the success of the operation is also dependent on the long-term strategy put in place in the area after the militants are eliminated or flushed out. "The army cannot stay forever," says Mohammad Afzal Khan 'Lala', an octogenarian Pashtun nationalist and former federal minister whose open defiance of the Taliban in Swat—he refused to flee from his native village near Matta despite being targeted by the TTP numerous times, suffering bullet injuries and losing near and dear ones—has made him a cause celebre in the area. He told INDIA TODAY: "We need a force to hold an area cleaned out by the army operation and the only way this can be done is to form and arm village defence committees that can defend their own areas. Right now the people are really terrorised, we need to boost their morale and make them believe in their own strength. So far, however, nothing has been done."

The Swat Taliban and their allied groups may not be in a position to take over Islamabad, and certainly are in no position to endanger Pakistani nuclear weapons, which the American media, in particular, is obsessed with. But the militants' successes in Malakand pose an abiding ideological threat, not just to the state of Pakistan but to other countries in the region such as Afghanistan and India. Counter-terrorism experts fear, for instance, that the "battle for survival" may unify the hitherto loosely allied commands of Al Qaida, the Taliban and local networks of militant groups. "Swat is a test case," says Abbas. Much depends on the outcome of this test.